

ADCLOD Podcast Series with Social Impact Founders

Episode 14: Neelam Chhiber, Industree Foundation

Neharika Vohra: Welcome to the ADCLOD podcast series with social impact founders, an initiative by the Ashank Desai Centre for Leadership and Organisational Development at IIM Ahmedabad, where we document and celebrate the leadership journeys of India's homegrown social entrepreneurs who have built impactful institutions from the ground up.

Neharika Vohra: In today's episode, we have the privilege of speaking with Neelam Chhiber, co-founder of Industree Foundation and one of India's original thinkers at the intersection of design, enterprise, gender and climate. Neelam trained as an industrial designer at the National Institute of Design in Ahmedabad. In 2000, she co-founded Industree Foundation in Bangalore to address the structural barriers keeping India's 200-million-strong artisan workforce — predominantly women — locked in informality, low wages and vulnerability. Over the years, she led Industree in building self-sustaining, women-owned producer collectives supplying to global brands like IKEA and H&M, developed the 6C framework for collective enterprise formation, and pioneered a blended capital model that has directly impacted over 600,000 lives across eight states in India. Neelam has been recognised as the Schwab Foundation Social Entrepreneur of the Year 2011 and the Economic Times Social Entrepreneur of the Year 2020, and received the NITI Aayog Women Transforming India Award in 2021. She is a founding member of Catalyst 2030 and Creative Dignity. Today's conversation will focus on her leadership journey from Industree's founding in 2000 through 2020 — two remarkable decades of building — and the thoughtful leadership transition she has shepherded as the organisation grows under its new CEO. Neelam, we welcome you to our podcast. It's a true honour to have you here.

Neelam Chhiber: Thank you, Professor Vohra. I think it's an honour for me to be here.

Neharika Vohra: It's a very pleasant task to be talking to you, because you're not only a trained designer, but someone who has used her sensibilities and practical sense to build an organisation that's worth talking about. So I'm very excited to talk to you about it. Maybe we could start with you giving us a picture of what Industree Foundation looked like at its peak under your leadership — the states it operated in, the producer communities it worked with, the range of initiatives, and the team you had built.

Neelam Chhiber: Industree Foundation is, in many ways, an offshoot. Industree, the social enterprise — the business — was started in 1994. When we started the concept of Industree, my co-founder, Mrs. Geeta Ram, who is today the chairperson of the Crafts Council of India, said, Neelam, we should build a company — we don't have to build an NGO. Those were her exact words, though she has a history of working in NGOs. In her words, crafts can stand on their own feet. So Industree built its NGO chops on private enterprise. By the time Industree Foundation was set up in 2000, we had built that discipline of ensuring the cash flow that pays people's salaries, keeps us functioning, and pays the artisans we give orders to.

Industree Foundation was set up because I went to Geeta and said, we're doing export orders, but we're not able to ship the right quality, because production at the village level isn't organised — we need to organise the supply chain better. And she said, Neelam, it's a tiny company as it is, and we don't have money; let's work with the Government of India. That's why Industree Foundation was set up. We went to the Office of the Development Commissioner (Handicrafts), Ministry of Textiles, and engaged with them. That's the founding of Industree Foundation.

Coming back to your question — Industree Foundation hasn't so much reached its peak; it's reaching its peak now. It took on some form of independent life 20 years after the private company was set up. But from 2000 onwards, it imbibed all the knowledge that the social business gained. That's why we are a very unique foundation: we believe that when you work with producers, you must understand markets. That's what livelihoods are like. In health, education or anything else, you can survive without a private arm — but not in livelihoods.

By 2020, when I started my exit, and by 2023, when I had exited, we were directly impacting about 12,000 artisans. Indirectly and cumulatively — my CEO did the maths in great detail — over the previous 20 years, through the private company and the nonprofit, we had impacted some 600,000 lives. He also worked out that we had cumulatively accessed about \$60 million worth of market. All that money had flowed into the system, and it had gone to producers, because obviously no one was taking profits home. It all went into the ecosystem that was being built.

The reason I'm spending so much time on this question is that impact can be deep, broad or light. For Industree, through my learning, growth and journey, it has always been about regular work. We have touched artisans for a month a year, or three months a year, but to us that was always meaningless. The women would say — and it's common sense — we all want a

regular income, so we can plan, budget, and send our children to a certain school or college. That's what the women in the villages want too. So that has been the drive at IndusTree Foundation: how do we enable regular, annualised income? That's how we measure our impact. So around 2014–15, 20 years after the IndusTree ecosystem was set up — the foundation was 2000, but the private company was 1994 — we set ourselves a vision called Mission Creative Million. We really believed that in the next 15 years, by 2030, we must have a deep impact on a million lives. We can't talk about tertiary or secondary impact. We should be able to show that this much money went into the bank accounts of a million women annually, through what we did.

Neharika Vohra: When you say 600,000, or reaching a million women, are these the number of producers directly engaged with you?

Neelam Chhiber: In 2023, some 11,000 or 12,000 were directly engaged — not with us, but in collectives, where income goes directly into bank accounts, paid by the collectives. By 2030, it needs to be a million. It's a big jump.

Neharika Vohra: You also set up something very creative — the 6C framework and the Flourish platform. Could you talk about those, so we get a sense of the whole ecosystem?

Neelam Chhiber: We had raised private investment, opened some ten stores and done retail, and we shut everything down during COVID. Flourish was an offshoot of that knowledge, and of the belief that brands must be owned by producers. I actually can't give you an example of an at-scale producer-owned brand — or, since today it's all about platforms, an at-scale producer-owned platform. Flourish was supposed to be that. Our experience with retail had taught us that brands eventually end up going deep — into a particular material or value chain. In fashion, it will be textiles; in accessories, certain materials. So it was very clear to us that the creative production sector in India is multi-material and multi-skill. It spans everything — metal, ceramic, textile, you name it — and we do it in the artisanal sector. Hence the platform, Flourish: enabling social entrepreneurs and master artisans to sell on it, and making it producer-owned. The social entrepreneurs can't own shares, but the makers who produce for them can. That was the dream behind Flourish. The shares are parked in trusts. It's something in motion — just happening in slow motion. We'll see where the idealism gets us.

Your other question was about the 6C framework. I'm not its originator. My husband, who is also a designer from NID, came in to help me run a skill development company we had set up with NSDC. I really believed there was a huge opportunity in that sphere — we'll talk about that later; it's a very tough sphere for our sector. We didn't know how to run it, because we're talking about self-employed artisans, so they can't be placed in jobs somewhere. So he came and said, Neelam, what have you done all these years? I told him, we enabled this to happen, then this, then this. And he drew the first 6C framework diagram — he sketched it out. He came up with the entire 6C framework idea, in the sense of putting down in a format everything we'd done over the years. So we eventually had a framework that is actually easy to understand. Today we've simplified it: two Cs fall on the supply side, two on the demand side, and two are the enablers. Anybody interested in producers of any kind, whether agricultural or creative, has to look at the demand side. And in the middle are the enablers — money, and of course a tech platform.

Neharika Vohra: So you've been a systems thinker in a way — it's not just feel-good help, but creating a system around it. That's really remarkable. You also trained as an industrial designer at NID Ahmedabad, and you've described how other fields, such as management, seemed deeply elitist to you at the time and disconnected from communities — which is true to a great extent. You've also mentioned that NID was careful not to allow or encourage its students to interfere insensitively with community livelihoods, the way it happens in many contexts. That was after its seminal initiative with IIM Ahmedabad through the Jawaja project — and even today, at every convocation, they come with goods they have produced, and we feel very happy about it. That project was overseen by our first director, Professor Ravi Matthai, and senior faculty from NID. How do you think your training shaped you, and how did the discomfort you felt with what you saw around you lead you to IndusTree Foundation?

Neelam Chhiber: I'm a complete product of design education — 100%. Of course, there's also my childhood: I'm from Punjab, and my mother would take me to see her family, a very nice, loving family, so I really believe the power of community is very strong. And NID taught us unlearning. Much later, I went to see an exhibition on how the Bauhaus curriculum was created. The design curriculum was created out of nothing — there was art and there was engineering. They had to create design because there were a lot of idle factories after World War I that had built ammunition and war machinery, so the Germans had to build a course in industrial design. And they started with unlearning. We were told to start from a dot, from a line. We had phenomenal teachers trained at the Bauhaus, and through environmental exposure we were taught to sensitise ourselves, watch and draw. That's exactly what I did with the sector.

And frankly, let's be honest — a lot of our internal drive comes from something personal. I had a lot of existential angst at NID. I was a little out of place. I kept asking, what is going on here? Why are we saying form is function? Why are we thinking like the Germans and the Scandinavians? Form is not function — look at how decorated our lives are in India, look at our saris, our textiles. There's no functional reason for all those designs on these things, but we do it. So I needed to understand what India was. I had also done industrial training at a factory in Delhi, and I felt I would never join a factory in India, because I didn't like the way labour was treated. That was another very big thing for me.

I also personally used to have a lot of angst when I had to do my design assignments. I didn't like working, so I used to think a lot about why we don't like working. Why do we feel pressured when we work? As a student, I felt highly pressured — from school we'd been mugging, studying, coming first in class, all that nonsense. So I said, I want to understand work as it traditionally was in our country. For me it was about that. I wanted to study the craft sector, which has been going on for centuries — people sitting in their villages making things. I wanted to understand that. That's why I went into the craft sector. And NID was super supportive — the faculty was amazing; they understood what it was all about.

I chose my diploma project — a six-month thesis project — in Bastar. One of my seniors at NID, whom I called, said, Neelam, choose a craft where you can work with your own hands, so that you're in it and not outside it. The best piece of advice I ever got. So I chose lost-wax metal casting, where you work in clay, wrap wax around it, and then cast it in brass. It's quite easy to pick up — otherwise, crafts are very difficult to pick up. And I chose Bastar because I wanted to see craft in an untouched environment. I didn't want to go to a modern cluster with a lot of change; I wanted to see how it was centuries ago. And I got everything I wouldn't even have remotely expected, because I saw things that built my foundation for the next 30 to 40 years. And it was because I used the design process — get to the bottom of it, get to the core. So I got there.

Neharika Vohra: That's so heartening to hear — and so is the point about how very often we forget to work with our hands, and the disconnect that produces in our thinking. It's even more important for people to hear about that today. Moving on to your organisation and setting it up: while the numbers are impressive, I'm sure the process had its own pain, and therefore learning for all of us. What you've said is very interesting — that the thesis around which Industree Foundation was formed was that structural barriers were keeping Indian artisans, especially women, locked in informality and low wages, and that this couldn't be solved by commerce alone or by good intentions alone; it required a foundation. What was the core insight that led you to this decision?

Neelam Chhiber: In 2000, we set up the foundation so that we could work on the supply side, thinking — very nobly — that government schemes would just plug in, and the private company would bring market funding. Even in the private company, we had chairs for artisans; I always believed in artisan ownership of brands. But I saw, first, that government schemes can never plug in. They take their own time, at their own pace. By then, the shops are ready and things are unfolding, and you don't have stock. There's never going to be coordination. So you have to raise private philanthropy.

And I'm saying this now because I think it's very important to say: there has always been an unseen hand. When your intentions are right — whatever you want to call it; I won't call it destiny, fate or karma — I believe there's an unseen hand. We learned organically, and we took decisions, right and wrong, over the years. But in retrospect, everything that happened was right. For a long time we never raised private philanthropy for the foundation. Around 2007–08, I was deeply frustrated. I knew I would never scale by spending 95% of my time on a social business and 5% on the foundation. It was very clear I was never going to make enough money to put back into the supply chain. And the government schemes weren't working out.

Then I did a course called Social Impact, set up by some people from the Bay Area, which later became the Dasra Social Impact programme. I was in its second cohort, and I remember showing my plan to the person from the Bay Area who set up the course — Charlie, still a dear friend. He said, Neelam, you need a blended model. You can't do this through a private company; you need a very strong nonprofit. I looked at him and tears came into my eyes — I was literally crying — because that's exactly why the nonprofit had been set up. But I didn't have the bandwidth to do both. I had two small children and elderly parents, and I was doing multiple things. I couldn't run both. But more importantly, I had become a market-facing person. When we started, I told Geeta, we'll have a company and we'll open a shop, because I want to understand how people buy. As a designer, when I did something with a craft community, I didn't know whether it would sell. I used to do government projects, and the government never sold the designs we made — they went into some storehouse and stayed there. I saw that. So I said, first I want to know whether we're doing things right or wrong. That's why the shop was set up. And I told Geeta — I stammer sometimes — I don't want to stand in a shop. But I did all of that, and I understood markets.

So I had become a market-facing person, and I felt: how will I ever raise philanthropy for my nonprofit? How will I put my hand out and ask someone for money? That was my biggest block, and I could never run the nonprofit. It went on like that. Then in 2007 I kind of gave in. I said, this won't happen this way, and I sent some emails out into the ether. Someone came to

meet me from the International Trade Centre — it was very unexpected — and I was sent on a two-week course in Geneva. I would never go for anything; I'd always say I don't have time. But I said, I have to go and learn something. There I saw attendees from all over the world — Africa, Belize, everywhere — and I thought, our Indian ecosystem is highly advanced; we can do this. I came back and joined the Social Impact course, and Charlie told me what he told me — and even then I didn't do anything about the nonprofit. I couldn't.

Then in 2013, I finally threw in the towel. After the Schwab Foundation award, I received the Womanity Foundation award — Womanity was set up by a person called Yann — and they asked, what help do you want? I said, I want to strengthen the nonprofit. I had finally accepted that a private company would never be able to do this. Even then, it took a couple of years. I think we built the scale-up model for Industree Foundation in 2015–16. And gradually I learned to change the way I spoke — I started using nonprofit language. It's a big jump from for-profit language to nonprofit language. So I retrained myself, slowly. You cannot enable the people who need you the most — we work with Dalits, with landless labourers — without access to public funding. It cannot be done through private capital. Let me tell you, if it could have been done through private capital, it would have been done. Am I saying all private capital is bad? It is not. But it's just not possible.

And there was another big block, I'll be very frank. Every time we said we would create the supply side and the private company would handle marketing, we were asked, why would any private philanthropy subsidise private marketing? That was a very clear signal. So I said, shut down the private company. And that's why I say there is still zero understanding of blended finance. Either one side doesn't understand, or the other side doesn't. Private capital is so important — why should your philanthropic dollars go into building markets? A private investor will put in money to build markets, and we'll give ownership to producers too; we'll work on it. But philanthropy couldn't understand that. Some of them do now. But I said, make it 100% producer-owned.

Neharika Vohra: Is the understanding of blended finance a little better now? Because it is complex, with multiple layers.

Neelam Chhiber: No. And also, Professor, it's a lived experience. The people taking decisions haven't lived it. It's a huge lived experience, and the people who have lived it understand it.

Neharika Vohra: So that's one more concept and one more system you were able to conceptualise and set up. Amazing. And very interestingly, you didn't leave craft at the level of a small craft shop — you were able to connect your producers to IKEA, H&M Home, Future Group and others. How did you build some of these commercial relationships? How did it all come together, and what has been your experience of making these connections?

Neelam Chhiber: The trigger was scale. I would do orders with one shop, and I'd order 20 pieces of something. We were also sub-suppliers to Fabindia, which by then had some 100 stores. Fabindia would order 200 pieces from us, and I'd think, they have 100 shops — why are they ordering only 200 pieces? I understand it now. But if you're going to supply 200 pieces to someone, how much work are you going to create at the back end? Nothing. So for me it was always about scale. The other thing was that there weren't many conscious consumers in India, so try exports — that was my gut. I've stood at something like 30 export fairs. You go, unpack, set up the stall, buyers come, buyers go. The same buyer doesn't come back the next year — they go to Vietnam, Cambodia, China. It's a crazy world out there, and we learned everything the hard way. Then someone at a fair in Germany told me, you need IKEA as a customer, because IKEA gives long, steady orders — it's one of those rare entities on the planet. And IKEA had also taken a decision to start a vertical for this kind of work.

The other reason to form collectives is very simple. We used to give orders to self-help groups, and in a self-help group, the person who provides the PAN card at the bank to register the group "becomes the owner" of the group. It could be a man or a woman, and that person decides how much in wages goes down the line. One fine day I said, I'm giving so many orders — I want to know how much the women are earning. I found they were earning 50 rupees a day — this was about 15 years ago. I was horror-stricken. I said, I need transparency. I will never build a model where I don't know how much money is reaching that woman. The only way to do that was to form a producer company. So we brought all the SHGs into one producer company and said, money will now flow through central finance directly into the women's accounts. That's how we enabled transparency of payment.

That's how the larger collective came about. And once you have a larger collective, you get into pricing, because to supply to IKEA you have to be competitive. And to be competitive, you can't lower wages, because you have to give the women a decent wage. So you have to get into productivity, into lean manufacturing — that's a big thing. But it can only happen when someone first gives you an order for 5,000 or 10,000 pieces. You can't do this on 100-piece orders. That was the learning.

Neharika Vohra: So basically market scale and finance.

Neelam Chhiber: And the reason we wanted to scale the market was for the producer — because we want more people to get work.

Neharika Vohra: Right — not for personal profit. And it's being produced somewhere else anyway, so why not by these women?

Neelam Chhiber: Yes — why not by India?

Neharika Vohra: Perfect. We've spoken a lot about the organisation and the breakthroughs you had to make to get here. My next question is this: from producer collectives that achieved self-sustainability after Industree's exit, to supply chains meeting global compliance standards, to women moving from informal daily labour to owning enterprises — how do you personally assess the work that has happened?

Neelam Chhiber: As I shared earlier, only a designer would do something as foolish as I did, because we didn't know anything about business or management. We didn't come from any enterprise background. We just jumped in at the deep end, stayed afloat, and did whatever we could. My biggest learning today is this. I always believed Industree had to be an organisation that bridged the consumer end and the producer end — that could think equally well about consumers and producers. I was speaking to my co-founder, Geeta Ram, just the day before yesterday, and she said, Neelam, we have to have more interest in the consumer, otherwise there will be no producer. But I said, Geeta, I have finally accepted this — and I've told my CEO too, so he feels a little less burdened. Today, with all these retail funders, it's going to become an era of mass customisation, and the people at the consumer end have to love consumer behaviour. So I've finally accepted — and it's my biggest learning — that you can't have one organisation do both. We must have a general understanding of consumer behaviour and how it's changing, but we cannot become lovers of consumer behaviour. For us, the producer will always come first. I've accepted that; it's a fact.

But we must have a very good grip on the consumer. So I now believe that our future — all our collectives' futures — lies in becoming sub-suppliers. We no longer supply to IKEA directly; we're a sub-supplier to an entity that supplies IKEA. It's a sweet spot — I've learned that. And supply components. Let the passionate designer take those components, make a fancy product for the consumer and sell it on Instagram. Leave that last layer to the person who really wants to do it, who loves it. That's my very big learning.

Neharika Vohra: Amazing. For your work at Industree, you need people with an unusual combination of skills — industrial design, supply chain management, community mobilisation, enterprise coaching. How did you find such people, where did they come from, and how did you build their capacity?

Neelam Chhiber: That again is the invisible hand. For the bamboo vertical we now have a lot of new young people, but if you look at the larger leadership team, about 10 to 15 people, some have been there 20 to 25 years. I don't know whether it was being a woman, or just being a very open, transparent person — as you can see I am — but I spent a lot of time with the people in my organisation, and I didn't do it consciously. I was in office eight or nine hours a day, and at a certain point I had stopped doing a lot of granular work, since there was a CEO and there were leaders. I would talk to people — not because I felt I should, but because I genuinely wanted to share everything I had learned.

The person who heads our nonprofit today, Neju George Abraham, came in to look after the nonprofit around 2007–08. I was very involved in the private company then — we had just taken investment and were launching stores — but we shared an office, and I would go and sit with him for an hour or two and share everything I was doing in the private company. He still remembers it. He had joined because he wanted to understand markets. He was a social activist working with women in North Karnataka, and he realised that unless he understood markets, he couldn't do anything for these landless women. So I knew why he had joined, and I shared every little thing with him. And I did that with everybody — designers and other people in the organisation too. I think it's my personality. All that sharing paid off. I think people need to understand something through a 360-degree lens. That's very important.

Neharika Vohra: How did people come to you? Did you advertise, or was it word of mouth?

Neelam Chhiber: Neju came through a regular job application — he applied through Naukri or something, not through a headhunting agency in the social sector. We had advertised for someone to head the nonprofit in 2007, and the match just happened. Some of my core people came to me as trainees from the Indian Institute of Crafts and Design — Ami Patel has been with us 25 years; she joined as an intern and stayed on. But in production, it's incredibly difficult, because for craft production and supply chains, there is nothing. We even went to an industrial engineering institute in Bombay and took interns from there — we said, set up a line, do lean. We've tried everything to find the right fit. But we realised that someone

like a lean engineer wants to go back to mainstream lean engineering; he won't stay in artisanal lean engineering. Then we looked for people from the leather industry, from textiles and garmenting. But in craft, there's a huge vacuum in artisanal production.

Neharika Vohra: And it continues to be so, I guess. The women producers at Industree typically had low literacy, economic vulnerability and deep social constraints. How was training and onboarding done for them?

Neelam Chhiber: When we had no money and no nonprofit — when we were just a private company — our collective was in Bangalore, in Koramangala. We were working with women in Koramangala village, because you need money to go rural. The minute we had a little money, the person who used to head my retail said, ma'am, I'll go and set up a producer company in Madurai, Tamil Nadu, because it was five hours from Bangalore. I had said, now we need to leave HSR Layout and go to the villages. So everything we did, we did whichever way we could, and then the teams there would mobilise. We already had teams working in Koramangala village, and they went to rural Tamil Nadu. And it happened because the people who went out and spearheaded all that work were not from a nonprofit background — none of them were. Neju was our first formal hire from a nonprofit background. They were private sector people who believed we needed to do this.

Neharika Vohra: Very nice. Did you find resistance in training these women, or were some things more difficult? For example, consistent quality is a big deal.

Neelam Chhiber: It's not easy. You can't build a collective by calling women from the outskirts of Madurai and telling them, this is your company. We did it, and obviously they didn't believe us. After ten years, now they say "company," and some of them say "my company." But ownership involves very old feudal concepts. Some of them got it, and now everyone in the collective knows it, because we've been there ten years. But it was always "madam's company." I'd say, no, not madam's company. But it's fine — you do this organically, and they handle the production, they handle everything.

We also drew a lot of inspiration from Amul, frankly. Nobody understood our model until we said, we want to build the Amul of creative manufacturing — then people would say, oh, I see, like that. Of course, Dr. Kurien was building a commodity business, selling milk, though today they do everything. But he spoke about professional management — he was the one who said, professionals in the service of farmers. He gave legitimacy to our model after I read his book. We really believed in the professional management layer. These women have studied up to the fourth standard — how can they manage a complex supply chain? My husband went to Japan and did the Toyota course for two weeks, came back and implemented lean. And if there's no lean engineer, lean collapses in the factory, by the way. So the professionals need to be there to keep an eye on things.

Now all the professionals have got it. But even for them, it takes ten years of work to understand that she needs to own it. Because in India, what is ownership? It's "we own it" — that's what you're taught. But every time, you have to drum it in: look, they own it, it's the women's; let them do it. Now, after ten years — because of the hassle and pain of doing it the other way — I think everyone is very happy saying it's theirs, and they can do it. And they're doing a great job, frankly. But even for a professional — professionals here are private sector people, not NGO people; they haven't been trained to say "she owns it" — internalising that takes time. It's lived. Everything is lived.

Neharika Vohra: And deep belief across the board — if there were inconsistent messaging, it wouldn't happen, but consistent messaging really changes things. From the work you've done with Industree, I'm sure the women's collectives have also changed the communities they are part of. What has been the virtuous cycle you've seen there?

Neelam Chhiber: I was shocked by something. A young American woman, who used to work for a 501(c)(3) in the US, came to do photography. She said, Neelam, I spoke to the young girls, and they said, we love coming to the production unit. These were small units in small villages — we would rent a small house where ten or fifteen women would come together to work, owned by the collective. And the girls said, otherwise we don't get to spend time together. This is Tamil Nadu, not Bihar — one of the most progressive states in the country. But in a Tamil village an hour or two from Madurai, girls don't say, okay, bye, I'm going to my friend's house. No. She's at home all day. She goes to college or school, comes back, and that's it. So they said, when we come to work here, we talk, we share.

So a lot of things — whether around gender violence, or women not being able to take decisions at home — come up there. A lot of our impact indicators are about women being able to take decisions at home: she should decide how her money is used, things like that. And women talk. When they talk: she does that, so I can do it too. That peer learning is super critical. Women resist working from home. During COVID they did it, but the minute COVID ended, they said, we want to come to a centre, we want to talk to each other. And when they talk, they're not discussing Tamil serials, let me tell you. They're talking about what happened in my house, this happened, that happened. And when someone is in a bad situation, she quietly tells someone

else, and they guide each other. And of course, workshops are done. All our gender strengthening has come from very solid gender training — we had USAID funding that enabled very high-level gender training, workshops and group work, from some of the best gender trainers in India.

You see the ripple effect across communities. And our biggest test is this: when you're in a community, you dig your heels in and stay as long as you can. Tamil Nadu was one particular example. Odisha scaled after Tamil Nadu, and in Odisha, from day one, the women have had to depend very little on external professionals. Partly that's because Tamil Nadu was exporting to IKEA, where compliance was extremely stringent — surprise audits and all — so professionals had to play a stronger role. Odisha is local supply; it goes to the local market. They sell leaf plates. That's why I'm pushing for local markets and more commodity products — because it's simpler for the women to run things themselves. They're compliant, and we can export from any of these units. But it's not a very high-end product where you check humidity, fungus, pests and so on — here everything is checked too, even for the plates, but she can get into an auto and take the plates to the local shop herself. And then she understands the whole thing. So I really believe there's huge scope to build more. At one end you do exports at some volume, and at the other you must also look at more commodity products and more local-economy work. It's much easier for the women to take ownership there.

Neharika Vohra: What is the break-up in the organisation between women producers and the professional layer?

Neelam Chhiber: In a producer company, women producers are 98 or 99%. The professional layer is shrinking every day — that's the CEO's biggest job — because the bigger the professional layer, the longer it takes to reach self-sustainability. The professionals sit on the foundation's books, and at some point they have to stop sitting on the foundation's books. That's why it's shrinking rapidly. But it's very tiny.

Neharika Vohra: Another thing you did that was quite amazing is taking the 6C model and making it available for others to adopt through your incubator and accelerator programmes. How did you approach transferring a model that was so deeply relational and contextual — built through years of community trust — into something others could use?

Neelam Chhiber: The interesting thing about scale is that we didn't do the scale journey alone. At some point, we got involved with the societal platform work that Nandan Nilekani and others initiated after Aadhaar. We engaged with them for some time and learned a lot — about exponential scale. We could reach a million women, but not 10 million or 20 million, and we definitely couldn't take the model global. So we learned about doing deep work and broad work. We built that ourselves, and the 6C framework helped, because it gave us a structure to build around. I won't go into it at length, but we learned a lot about scale thinking from them.

It became clear that "deep" meant enabling collectives. And now, with bamboo, which the CEO is propelling forward, we are working with existing collectives that state governments already have. Building on something that already exists is happening even in the deep work. We are no longer doing the deep work ourselves — we are enabling the State Rural Livelihood Missions to do it. That's how the deep work is growing. It's very deep work, but Indutree won't do it directly; we'll ensure a deep methodology is carried out by the State Rural Livelihood Missions and others. And "broad" meant opening out what we do to other organisations, and that's how the regional programme started. This was before bamboo, because when we looked at the million number, we had to break it up by type of pathway.

Through that programme, about 100 NGOs and social enterprises have gone through so far; it's been running for five years. We also learned that all this happens through co-creation and collaboration. I don't run the regional programme. It was conceived and designed by Jacob Mathew, and he and a team run it — a lot of young people run it now, and he's only a mentor. The whole idea was that scale will happen through co-creation and collaboration, and collaboration never happens without co-creation. You can't expect five entities to collaborate unless they have co-created together — unless it's their idea, a joint idea. One person's idea can't be thrust on anybody else. So that's how the programme works. We say, look, we came up with 6C and we'll share it, and if anybody else has something, we'd all like to learn together. It's a co-learning platform, and it's run in a very gentle way.

Neharika Vohra: And do you see a lot of NGOs adopting it?

Neelam Chhiber: People like it because of its broad-spectrum view. It says: look, you're small — you're doing 5, 10, 20 or 50 lakh rupees in sales — but if you ever wanted to scale, what would happen to your supply chain? It's all laid out, and Indutree's learnings and lived experience are shared. A lot of Indutree staff go and take sessions, so it's very practical knowledge. And of course, I know how difficult it is to run a blended model — I'm the first to say so. So we don't expect everyone to have a nonprofit and a for-profit, but everything is opened out to them. They know what's in store. They're not going in blind the way we did, and they can make their choices. As I said, even in our sector, having your peers and talking

with them helps a lot of people. Some people get helped just by having a chat with me when I meet them somewhere. I might only go for a couple of ten-minute sessions, but everyone knows we're there — if they have a doubt, they can call someone and ask. So you build a network.

Neharika Vohra: That's amazing, and quite rare. People usually hide proprietary information rather than share it. I think that's an amazing step you've taken, and all of us can learn from it.

Neelam Chhiber: Professor Vohra, I firmly believe that we developed this with private investment and public investment, so it is not my proprietary information. I tell everyone, it's somebody else's money. Our investors lost all their money — it all went down the drain. Even for that, I owe society. I don't owe my investors.

Neharika Vohra: I hear you, but it still takes something to codify what is tacit and bring it out for replication. Kudos to you for doing that. A few other questions about community and social leadership. Have you had one or two experiences where you were floored by how the women took ownership? It would be lovely to hear those.

Neelam Chhiber: Yes. After COVID, we had a master weaver outside Madurai. Other women would take three days to make a basket; she would make it in half a day. She was really something. She had sorted it all out — one hour at this time, one hour at that time, one hour whenever she was free. She bought a scooter, everything. They really go in and do their thing. They'll buy a washing machine, get a scooter, redeem all the gold they had pawned. There are so many examples.

One I always give is from a gender training workshop — I wasn't there, but I was told — where the women said, we have never eaten hot food. We have never eaten hot food. They talked about it in the workshops, and now they go home and eat hot food. And one woman said, I always treated my son and daughter differently — the same old story: the chicken has two legs, there are two boys, they get the legs. She said, now I make sure I give my daughter the best food. These are the kinds of examples. And financially, of course, they have their own money and the power to spend it. I'm telling you — this is Tamil Nadu — you sit in a group meeting and ask, what will you do with your money? And they say, we will buy books and stationery for our children. Can you believe it? We said, what — your husband doesn't have money for books? But no, the women want to do this for their children themselves. They don't want to go and discuss it with their husbands. I have to get them this — she wants to do it herself.

Neharika Vohra: Amazing. Now to the last part of our interview. In many social impact organisations, one of the biggest questions is succession. The leader stays on, or can't give up control, or there isn't a second line that has been developed or trained. But you have done something we can all talk about and learn from: in the midst of reaching your potential, you decided to step out and let somebody else take the organisation to the next stage. I would love to hear your thought process, your experience, and how you think about it in retrospect.

Neelam Chhiber: See, I started my diploma project at 22 or so — that was 1986. I did a lot of granular work. I was in the field, waiting at bus stops in the hot sun, doing whatever had to be done. By the time I hit 54, I knew I was no longer capable of granular work. I wasn't going to go down into every little detail; I had become more meta. I knew I was never going back there — it was impossible. And with the scale-up coming, it was very clear. In 2023, our annual report showed 11,000 in direct impact. How was that going to become a million in direct impact in seven or eight years — or ten, if you stretch your imagination? We knew the level of granular detail that would take, and I didn't have it. Who did? This was hardcore nonprofit work now, because the model had started to emerge. USAID had funded us in 2020, bamboo had happened and needed to be scaled, and it was very clear that bamboo was completely the right track. We needed somebody with an agro-plantation, agricultural background — and, as I said, it's the hand of whatever — we had Neju in our system. He's from an agricultural background and understands agriculture very well. So everything fell into place; it was a no-brainer.

Plus, I was very clear: I've worked 40 years, from 22 to 62. It's a good innings, and given the kind of work and detail required now, I don't need to hang on for anything. That's what happens when people keep peering over someone's shoulder. So we went through a process. We brought in a change management entity — a global HR firm — who came in for two years and coached the senior leaders. At one point one of them said, ma'am, I don't want any more coaches and mentors — I've got three or four of them. It was like that. So we did a process, and it was done collectively. At first I believed a lot in collective leadership. Then a board member said, Neelam, when they go to fundraise, the donor will ask, who do I call? Give me a name — who is the leader? You can't do without that. So we had to appoint one leader, and we did it in a very systematic way. And it was very clear that you don't peer over anyone's shoulder — it has to be a clean break. I left Bangalore and moved to Goa, and I really, really trust the teams. As I said, it's the biggest blessing I have — not just the CEO, but all the teams. We've been really blessed that over the years the right talent came in and stayed, and more fresh talent is coming in on that fertile foundation.

Neharika Vohra: Are you on the board?

Neelam Chhiber: Yes, I'm on the board. I attend three board meetings a year virtually, and one physically in Bangalore. When I go to Bangalore, I don't even go to the office now, because I really have so much faith and trust, and things are going so well — we are growing, and it's brilliant.

Neharika Vohra: Very good. Looking back over the 40 years of your work and the 20 years of Industree Foundation, is there any regret? Anything you would not do, or would do differently?

Neelam Chhiber: I would have focused on the nonprofit earlier — in 2008, when I was told to. But I wasn't ready for it. I had to really fail at the for-profit first. And what does "fail" mean? One day I woke up — and this is the learning; otherwise the CEO would be doing now what I did then, but he has learned, and he knows it won't work. We used to sell fashion — clothes made by a parallel producer company, with handloom fabric coming from a producer collective — and we had to sell a kurta at an MRP of, say, 1,999 or 2,000 rupees. Fabindia sells a kurta at 2,000; Westside sells one; Pantaloons sells one; everybody sells a kurta at 2,000. Which customer is checking that this one comes from a producer company and is 100% handloom?

Neharika Vohra: Very few.

Neelam Chhiber: So it struck me one day that the investor dollars I had raised were not enough for the investment needed at the production end. I had to sell at an MRP of 2,000, otherwise nobody would buy in the first place. So I was ending up burning somebody's money to do a great thing that I wasn't achieving. I wasn't able to do justice either to the producer company or to the market end. That's when I understood that you cannot do this through private capital. You cannot. Look at all this Prada and Kolhapuri chappal business happening now. It's a very complex situation in production.

Neharika Vohra: Absolutely. My last question — and it's been a great evening talking to you. For a young designer, social entrepreneur or development practitioner listening to this conversation — someone who wants to work at the intersection of craft, commerce, gender and sustainability, which is already a mouthful — what are two or three things you would tell them to keep in mind, so that they at least have a chance to succeed?

Neelam Chhiber: I believe you need to be rooted in something — rooted in a community. I took a decision to stay in Bangalore because I wanted my children to go to a proper school, and I knew I could never be rooted in a rural community — I knew my DNA. So I was rooted in an urban setting, but then we moved rural, and Neju is on the road today. Our teams are rooted in rural communities. I succeeded only because I spent two or three years living in the field — I did my rooting. And after that, for three or four years, I worked in Saharanpur, Khurja, Agra — name it, everywhere. So I rooted myself in communities for six or seven years. It's tough these days, I'll be frank — it's a different time, and I don't want to give anybody an impossible task. But try to root yourself as much as you can. That's a very good impetus for taking the right decisions, because you then function from first-hand knowledge, and functioning from first-hand knowledge is very important. That's my advice whenever young people come to me. And if you really can't do that, do whatever you can, and the path will open. I believe in that too. If something is tough for you to start now, and your intentions are right, things will work out. You will find the right partner to work with — someone who is rooted, for example. That's about it.

Neharika Vohra: Thank you so much. What I've heard is that when you take on a really complex problem, you also need to come up with complex, systemic solutions rooted in the groups you're trying to serve. It can't just be a theory or an idea. That's a great learning for anyone who wants to build something at scale and help communities that are themselves very widely distributed. Thank you so much for the conversation.